

Enderton's Elements of Set Theory

Malcolm

Started 1st May 2026

Contents

1	Axioms and Operations	2
1.1	Axioms I	2
1.1.1	Definitions	4

Chapter 1

Axioms and Operations

1.1 Axioms I

Extensionality axiom

If two sets have the exact same members, then they are equal:

$$\forall A \forall B [\forall x (x \in A \leftrightarrow x \in B) \rightarrow A = B]$$

(The nested implication is not an equivalence because the other direction is already true. Declaring it would be redundant.)

Empty set axiom

There is a set having no members:

$$\exists B \forall x (x \notin B)$$

Pairing axiom

For any sets u and v , there is a set having as members just u and v :

$$\forall u \forall v \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x = u \text{ or } x = v)$$

Union axiom, Preliminary form

For any sets a and b , there is a set whose members are those sets belonging either to a or to b (or both):

$$\forall a \forall b \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in a \text{ or } x \in b)$$

(next page)

Power set axiom

For any set a , there is a set whose members are exactly the subsets of a :

$$\forall a \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \subseteq a)$$

We can rewrite $x \subseteq a$ in terms of the definition of $\subseteq$:

$$\forall t (t \in x \rightarrow t \in a)$$

This list will be further expanded later to include

- Subset axioms
- Replacement axioms
- Infinity axiom
- Regularity axiom
- Choice axiom

The union axiom will be also be restated in a stronger form.

1.1.1 Definitions

Definition 1.1. $\emptyset$ is the set having no members.

This definition bestows the name “ $\emptyset$ ” on a certain set. When we write down such a definition we must be sure of two things: that there exists such a set and that there cannot be more than one set having no members. The empty set axiom provides the first fact and extensionality provides the second. Without both facts the symbol “ $\emptyset$ ” would not be well defined.

Definition 1.2.

- For any sets u and v , the **pair set** $\{u, v\}$ is the set whose members are u and v .
- For any sets a and b , the **union** $a \cup b$ is the set whose members are those sets belonging either to a or to b (or both).
- For any set a , the **power set** $\mathcal{P}a$ is the set whose members are exactly the subsets of a .

The existence and uniqueness proofs guaranteeing all of these definitions can be proved using the empty set axiom, the pairing axiom, the union axiom, and the power set axiom respectively, each in combination with the extensionality axiom.

We can use the pairing and union together to form other finite sets. Given any x we can denote the pair set $\{x, x\}$ as the *singleton* $\{x\}$ (since the pair exists and is unique). For any given x_1, x_2, x_3 we can define

$$\{x_1, x_2, x_3\} = \{x_1, x_2\} \cup \{x_3\}$$

(since the union exists and is unique for any two particular sets). Similarly we can define $\{x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4\}$ and so forth.